

investing out of alignment with my values? Who or what is influencing these decisions?

These questions matter because we're social creatures, and along with this comes a need to be accepted by others. It's a normal part of being human, and it's why so many of us feel the need to act based on the expectations of those around us and even society in general—often at the expense of what we want for ourselves. This need to be accepted by others can become so great that it starts affecting our everyday lives. Our finances don't sit in isolation from our everyday lives, which means this need for acceptance affects our finances, too. So, instead of making our financial decisions based on what we want for ourselves, our decisions become based on what we think others consider to be right. Asking yourself questions like the ones above will help you determine if you're doing things because you think they're the right thing to do or because you're afraid of being judged.

Now, spending, investing or having experiences because we think it's the right thing or the socially acceptable thing to do isn't problematic in and of itself. But it becomes problematic when the right thing or expected thing to do is the wrong thing for us.

Especially if it means we're financially sabotaging or even financially harming ourselves because it's not something we value or want for ourselves. For example, you might have grown up in an affluent suburb and attended a private school and now everyone is taking up large mortgages and buying property to settle down in close to home. And pressuring you to do the same. The problem is, you don't want to be burdened with a large mortgage, you understand you can't 'eat your home' and you want to make sure you have enough free cashflow to invest in other asset classes. If you become a product of your environment, however, you may in the end succumb to the pressure to buy the expensive home. Or conversely, you may have grown up in a poor socio-economic neighbourhood but you have a dream of starting a global business which is laughed at by your peers as unattainable so you begin to doubt whether that financial goal can really be possible for you. In both instances, the question to ask yourself is: How can I expand my environment so I receive different financial influences?